

By Talha Memon

To what extent should we be concerned about artificial intelligence developments today?

Amidst a surge in German submarine attacks on the British during the Second World War, the famed British computer scientist, Alan Turing cracked Germany's enigma code and rendered German communication lines and their efforts futile. He also helped to pioneer the development of artificial intelligence, which refers to technology that shares many parallels with cognitive, human intelligence. In the contemporary era, many experts have described the growing use of AI as an indicator of the fifth industrial revolution, and argue that artificial intelligence could herald a new age of unprecedented growth in human creativity and ingenuity. On the other hand, many critics of artificial intelligence view it as an existential threat, capable of subverting us and our way of life. Whilst there is some credence to such radical opinions, I still believe that we should not be concerned about the developments of artificial intelligence today because artificial intelligence can be leveraged upon to improve societies and our entire world.

Critics of artificial intelligence, as elaborated upon earlier, are skeptical about artificial intelligence and are concerned about its contemporary developments because they believe that it is pernicious and can be exploited by malevolent individuals and governments. A stark reminder about the dangers of AI is its rampant usage in the creation of deepfakes, which can and has been used to undermine the credibility and tarnish the reputation of many victims, the vast majority of whom are women. Deepfakes use algorithms, making use of a vast collection of data to mimic the movement of human lips, eyebrows and the sounds of voices. In the early developments of deepfake technology, Russia notoriously leveraged on it, creating a video depicting Volodymyr Zelensky, the President of Ukraine ordering Ukrainian troops to demobilise and surrender to the invading Russian forces. Whilst the intentions of this video were deplorable as they sought to undermine Ukraine's sovereignty and sap Ukrainian morale, it was not particularly effective as deepfake technology was still in its seminal phase. Today however, deepfake technology has made significant strides, and many have claimed that they are unable to distinguish between an actual video and an authentic video. A pertinent example of this could be seen in Rana Ayyub, a famed Indian journalist who sought to investigate the BJP's complicity in the 2002 Gujarat riots. Many Hindutva supporters circulated videos depicting her in compromising positions, in a deliberate misogynistic attack to damage her reputation as a journalist. Despite repeatedly demanding the police to investigate those who created and circulated those videos, the Delhi police closed their investigations as they cited an inability to track down and apprehend the individuals responsible due to the difficulty in doing so. This highlights an even more pressing issue of AI, where criminals can escape from law and justice, due in part to its inherent esoteric nature. Moreover, artificial intelligence has also been deployed by governments, some of whom have used it to commit human rights violations on a systemic scale. China has used AI in the form of facial-tracking technology, monitoring and surveillance in its 'reformation' camps in Uyghur-majority areas. Many analysts have described China's use of AI as expediting genocide, which further reinforces AI's propensity for malicious use. Nonetheless, many governments are actively implementing legislation against the use of deepfake technology, and it is still highly unlikely for AI to herald an Orwellian age as such a system would be prone to hacking and other serious vulnerabilities, and thus these concerns are to a certain degree, overblown.

Moreover, we should not be concerned about the development of AI because it can help us address perennial issues and find solutions to difficult problems. A growing field within artificial intelligence itself is Big Data Analytics, which refers to the collection of massive amounts of data, utilising algorithms to detect trends and patterns and leveraging upon such patterns to discover solutions. Amidst the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war, Palantir has stepped up to offer Ukraine their services to aid them in clearing the minefields that Russia has set up all over the country, especially in the Eastern agricultural areas. When the war began, UN experts claimed that it would take 737 years and US\$ 37 billion to clear all the mines that Russia had set up, as well as innumerable lives. Yet with Palantir's big data analytics software, Ukraine is already in the process of clearing minefields across its rural areas, enabling Ukraine's farmers to return to their lands and livelihoods. Countries like Bosnia, Cambodia and Serbia have also sought the use of AI to address their minefield problems following Ukraine's use. Moreover, tractor and farming technology giant John Deere has also used artificial intelligence to help increase the efficiency of farming and help save costs for farmers by reducing the probability of seeding the same land excessively. This could in turn help address starvation and food scarcity, a perennial issue that has plagued humanity for thousands of years, across civilizations

In addition, we should not be concerned about the development of artificial intelligence because AI could serve as the catapult to boost human productivity and creativity. Whilst a study conducted by Mckinsey found that nearly 30% of all jobs could be displaced by artificial intelligence, and many artists have put up resistance against the use of AI because they believe it will displace them entirely, it would be incisive to recognise that such views are opaque and not reflective of the true benefit workers could reap from it. AI tools like Gemini and Dall-E have become increasingly known for their image generation capabilities. Adobe Photoshop has also implemented artificial intelligence, which artists have used to expedite processes like idea generation, layering and filling out spaces. This is especially beneficial for artists because they can utilise such technology to focus on the creative process of their work, and it also enhances their productivity as they need not concern themselves with minute or miniscule details. Moreover, for the larger workforce, artificial intelligence could serve as the catalyst for them to expand their skills and knowledge so as to achieve higher-paying jobs and even jobs in artificial intelligence itself. For instance, in Singapore, through the Myskillsfuture program and the lifelong learning initiatives, the government has encouraged many workers to adapt new skills such as programming languages and software development through polytechnic diplomas. Whilst the impetus for this is undeniably the concern that many workers could end up structurally unemployed because of AI, such policies could actually be very beneficial for Singapore's economy, especially at addressing the productivity slump Singapore has undergone in recent years. Henceforth, we should not be concerned about AI, because whilst it may indeed result in structural unemployment, it could deliver the productivity boost developed countries need to overcome their relative economic stagnation.

Lastly, we should not be concerned about the development of AI because we will continue to maintain primacy and precedence above it. Whilst many have envisioned a dystopian, kafkaesque future where AI revolts against us and wages war on us, it is simply impossible that corporations and governments alike cannot bring themselves to allow such AI to be used because of the moral ambiguity of doing so. Whilst many have criticized Israel's use of

AI amidst the ongoing Israel-Hamas war, the missiles that are launched leveraging such technology ultimately necessitate human intervention in the form of granting approval.

In conclusion, we should not be concerned about the development of artificial intelligence because the benefits greatly exceed its harms and its harms are increasingly being tackled and curtailed. In the future, this trend is likely to persist. Nonetheless, we must continue to remain vigilant about AI, as we simply cannot afford to have the same excesses that we did during the first industrial revolution and subsequent ones, as such developments deteriorated the welfare and sanctity of our planet. Henceforth, using lessons from history, we should welcome AI with open arms, but maintain a close, watchful eye over its potential excesses.

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Is religion still relevant in today's world?

The ancient Greeks worshipped Zeus and Atlas. Their descendants today are primarily Orthodox Christians. Ancient Greece, be it in the states of Sparta or Macedon, were inarguably one of the greatest civilizations to have ever emerged, bringing to the world Socrates, Alexander and Plato. Today, Greece stands economically ravaged and politically weak. This transformation is seen in other civilizations, like the Persians who were once Zoroastrian but now espouse Shia Islam. These circumstances highlight how the religions we adhere to may rise and fall. In the contemporary era, we are in an epoch characterised by science and technology, an emphasis on human rights, and the rise of a myriad of philosophies like Absurdism and Gen-Z esque doomerism. Such circumstances beg the question, is religion truly relevant today? If it is, does it provide value? Proponents of religion would argue that religion can serve as a source of solace and serenity. Whilst I do concede that there is inherent value in the solace that religion could provide, I am still of the view that religion is largely irrelevant today, and does not provide substantial value as we live in the information age.

Proponents of religion argue that religion is especially relevant today and can provide guidance on how to live a morally righteous and benevolent life. In today's world, many of us find ourselves in a cycle of existential crises, and we may struggle to find meaning and purpose as a result. The cycle of existential crises undeniably comes about due to how modern science often comes into direct conflict with religion, and the vast majority of schools, especially in the Western Hemisphere emphasize secular subjects over religion. For instance, in many high schools in the USA, students are taught Charles Darwins' theory of evolution, which hypothesises that human beings evolved over time and are related to primates. This comes into direct conflict with Christianity and Judaism, which largely emphasize creationism. Such conflicts cause many to be lost, without meaning as they struggle to reconcile such conflicts between science and their faith. Religion on the other hand, unlike science, can provide meaning and purpose. For instance, even in the face of the Russian invasion of Chechnya, many Chechens saw Islam as a guiding force of support

and courage to pursue their quest to manifest their own destiny, and fought to the bitter end in sacrifice for their people. We can draw similar parallels between how religion helped Chechens in their quest for sovereignty as we can see in the Palestinians amidst the Israeli-Hamas conflict. Even in the face of daily shelling and starvation, many Palestinians fasted during the Islamic holy month of Ramadhan, which was a signal to the world of their resistance and strength through such trying times. Henceforth, religion can still be argued to be relevant and of value, especially in the context of human suffering.

Nonetheless however, it is essential to recognise that whilst religion can indeed provide purpose and meaning, it can empower individuals to rebel against the norms and standards of the twenty-first century. Our era is characterised by beliefs such as egalitarianism, women's rights and freedom of speech and expression. Certain interpretations of religions may work against such beliefs, even though such values should inarguably be held as sacrosanct, even more than the religions themselves as these values are universal and all-encompassing, unlike religion. For instance, a conflict between the issue of women's rights and religion is seen in Singapore amongst the Muslim community, the vast majority of whom subscribe to the Shafi' school of thought. This school of thought advocates for female genital mutilation (FGM), which contravenes issues such as bodily autonomy and constitutes a violation of a girls' rights, as many girls who undergo FGM are as young as three months old. Beyond female genital mutilation, another recurring issue amongst certain religions is that they are fundamentally ethnoreligions, and do not accept converts from other ethnicities. Judaism has come under significant criticism for its perceived emphasis on 'Jews as the chosen people', which suggests that Jews are inherently superior to other groups. Whilst such views are not particularly pertinent amongst other ethnoreligions like Sikhism, it is still fair to criticize Sikhism for their lack of acceptance of other races and promotion of untouchability, which are views that simply should not persist in this era of egalitarianism and equity. Henceforth, religion provides little value as various interpretations condone values that stand diametrically opposed to those that characterise our modern era.

Aside from conflicting with the values of our era, religion also provides little value today as religion conflicts with science & technology. Whilst this would not be as large of an issue on its own, religion becomes a fundamental threat to a society when its monks and priests openly espouse anti-scientific views and propagate misinformation. During the coronavirus pandemic, the Christian missionary group 'Healing the divide' propagated vaccine skepticism and put forth sensationalist views such as how the rise in autistic children can be attributed to higher vaccination rates. They implored their followers to reject government mandates on vaccinations. Given Singapore's status as one of the densest cities in the world that was especially vulnerable to Covid-19, 'Healing the divide' actively sought to undermine the government's efforts to ameliorate the Covid situation, which highlights how it can be used for malignant purposes

Moreover, religion provides little value today due to the deterioration of its influence as an institution and its status as a source of enlightenment and understanding. Considering the aforementioned context of how 'Healing the divide' sought to promote vaccine skepticism, it seems ironic then that the Catholic Church established the first institution solely dedicated to the sciences. Galileo Galilei, although faced persecution from the Catholic Church for his rejection of heliocentrism, highlights how Catholics during the enlightenment era sought to challenge conventional views and mindsets. The Catholic Church of old, like many other

religions, used to provide a space for debate, argument and discussion of areas beyond merely theology. In the contemporary era however, the Catholic Church and its constituent institutions serve as nothing more than organisations dedicated to the salvation of Catholic peoples and the propagation of Catholic beliefs. Islam shares similar parallels, as the scientific discoveries of the Islamic Golden Age continue to influence our world. Yet today, only a modicum of Nobel prize winners are Muslims, and innovation in the Islamic world pales in comparison to both the West and the East. Moreover, atheism and agnosticism, ideologies that largely reject organised religion have seen considerable growth in recent decades, thus even the role religion once had in peoples' lives is dwindling entirely.

In conclusion, whilst religion can provide a sense of solace, it is ultimately nothing more than a feeling and in this era, we ought to be utilitarian and pragmatic. Inarguably, atheistic philosophies, like absurdism and solipsism could very well provide the same comfort and solace that religion can. To counter the sense of meaninglessness some of us may be prepositioned to experience, we must consider promoting such philosophies, in the same manner that religions propagate their beliefs. In this way, we can maximize the minute value religion provides, whilst minimizing its excesses and negatives.

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